



FLASHPOINT

POLESTAR INSIGHTS

REPORTING PERIOD: 18 MAY 2026 - 24 MAY 2026

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

The picture this week is one to plan around for short-notice protest disruption, not a return to quiet: Pakistan sees the most activity, with the most serious reaching High on the protest and public-order range. Activity is being shaped by named opposition mobilisation and sectoral chamber and union action.

Activity is regional rather than confined to one country: it spans South Asia, East Asia, Southeast Asia and Pacific, with Pakistan seeing the most. The most serious incidents sit toward the upper end of the protest and public-order range rather than the armed-conflict tail (which sits out of scope for Flashpoint), which keeps the focus squarely on protest disruption rather than armed violence.

Bottom line for the next 7-14 days: the time from an announced protest to street-level disruption stays short - historically 24-72 hours once a policy trigger occurs. Detailed activism, civil-unrest, forecast and country sections follow.

FAST FACTS

REPORTING PERIOD 18 May - 24 May 2026	RECORDS IN WINDOW 30	HIGHEST SEVERITY High Highest rating this week
TOP ISSUE TYPE Protest 19 records	MOST AFFECTED COUNTRY Pakistan 8 records	LATEST INCIDENT 23 May 2026

ACTIVISM AND PROTEST READ

Across 18 May - 24 May 2026 the activism picture is led by "Thousands rally in Tokyo against Takaichi government's push to revise pacifist constitution", which falls in the Moderate severity band.

Activity is being driven by named opposition mobilisation, sectoral chamber and union action and student and campus activism - several separate organising efforts that are harder for authorities to contain than a single-issue wave and that historically turn into rolling road action within 24-72 hours of an announced date.

Operationally, the pressure points to watch are city-centre commercial districts, court complexes, party headquarters, ministry quarters and the main intercity arteries. Staff movement, last-mile logistics and customer-facing footfall are the surfaces that feel the effect first; supply-chain friction from sectoral walkouts tracks one news cycle behind.

DATE	ISSUE	TITLE	SEVERITY
23 May 2026	Protest	PTI launches protest drive for Imran's release	MODERATE
22 May 2026	Protest	Bangladesh Labour Congress-BNC holds a protest march in front of the National Press Club in the capital on Friday, demanding justice for the brutal murder and rape of all daughters and women, including Ramisa.	LOW
22 May 2026	Protest	Indonesia Gaza Flotilla Protest	LOW
22 May 2026	Protest	Rights organisations protest over brutal rape-murder of minor girl in Bangladesh	LOW
22 May 2026	Protest	Top-10 players plan Roland Garros prize-money protest	LOW
22 May 2026	Protest	PTI workers stage protests in various cities, defy Section 144 in Islamabad	HIGH
21 May 2026	Strike / labour action	Top UN court says right to strike protected in key labour treaty	LOW
21 May 2026	Strike / labour action	Union calls strike at South Korea chip giant Samsung Electronics	LOW
21 May 2026	Protest	Thousands rally in Tokyo against Takaichi government's push to revise pacifist constitution	MODERATE
21 May 2026	Strike / labour action	Cab , auto strike in Delhi - NCR : Three - day Chakka jam in Capital , Noida , Gurugram and Ghaziabad begins today ; check what affected for commuters	LOW
21 May 2026	Protest	Pakistan : Students hold protest in Balochistan against delay in laptop distribution , internet disruption	LOW
21 May 2026	Strike / labour action	ACT public schools : May 22 strike to delay morning traffic	LOW

CIVIL UNREST AND PUBLIC ORDER READ

Little riot, clash, crackdown, curfew or security-force activity was reported across 18 May - 24 May 2026. A quiet stretch for civil unrest alongside continuing protest activity usually means the authorities have held back from mass arrests or curfew orders - useful, but it can reverse within days if a protest crosses a policy line.

Keep tracking police statements, local government orders, internet-shutdown notices and any move to call in the military. These tend to come ahead of curfews and visible street-level enforcement.

No civil-unrest reporting this week.

FORECAST: NEXT 7-14 DAYS

COUNTRY	SIGNAL	OPERATIONAL MEANING
Bangladesh	Gender-violence protest	Treat as leading indicator; confirm operating impact inside 24-48h.
Philippines	Union injunction ruling - sectoral strike risk (Manila)	Sectoral disruption pending court ruling; pre-position contingency supply.
India	Chemists' strike notice over e-pharmacy rules	Pharmacy supply disruption 24-72h ahead; brief procurement and customer-care.
Nepal	Civic protest march	Treat as leading indicator; confirm operating impact inside 24-48h.
Pakistan	Faculty / campus protest (Quetta)	Campus action seeds city-centre protests within a week; expect adjoining-road disruption.
Pakistan	Sectoral pay protest by transport / public-sector staff (Islamabad)	Sectoral walkout risk; brief logistics and field operations on local delays.

Confirmed upcoming events are listed in the table above and are the first things to plan around for the next 7-14 days. The outlook below builds on that schedule.

The upcoming-events table and the country breakdown point in slightly different directions. Pakistan sees the most activity this week and remains the most likely source of repeated disruption. The outlook highlights Bangladesh (Gender-violence protest) only because it has the clearest confirmed upcoming event - something to plan around for the next 7-14 days, not a sign that Bangladesh outweighs Pakistan on volume or seriousness. Plan for sustained, widespread disruption in Pakistan and treat the Bangladesh item as a fixed calendar date to act on.

Protest activity dominates at the moment, so the most likely escalation path is from announced rallies and trade-group walkouts into intermittent road closures and city-centre disruption. Risk increases if security forces respond with mass arrests, tear gas or curfew orders; risk eases if organisers stand down voluntarily or political talks open.

A note of caution: a quiet stretch is not a lasting easing in these countries. A single political event can bring activity flooding back within 48 hours, so treat this outlook as a starting point rather than a firm prediction.

REGIONAL AND COUNTRY VIEW

This week activity spans South Asia (led by Pakistan), East Asia (led by South Korea), Southeast Asia (led by Indonesia) and Pacific (led by Australia). It is genuinely regional rather than confined to any single sub-region; Pakistan sees the most activity but is not the whole story, and businesses with a presence across several APAC capitals should treat this as a coordinated rather than localised picture.

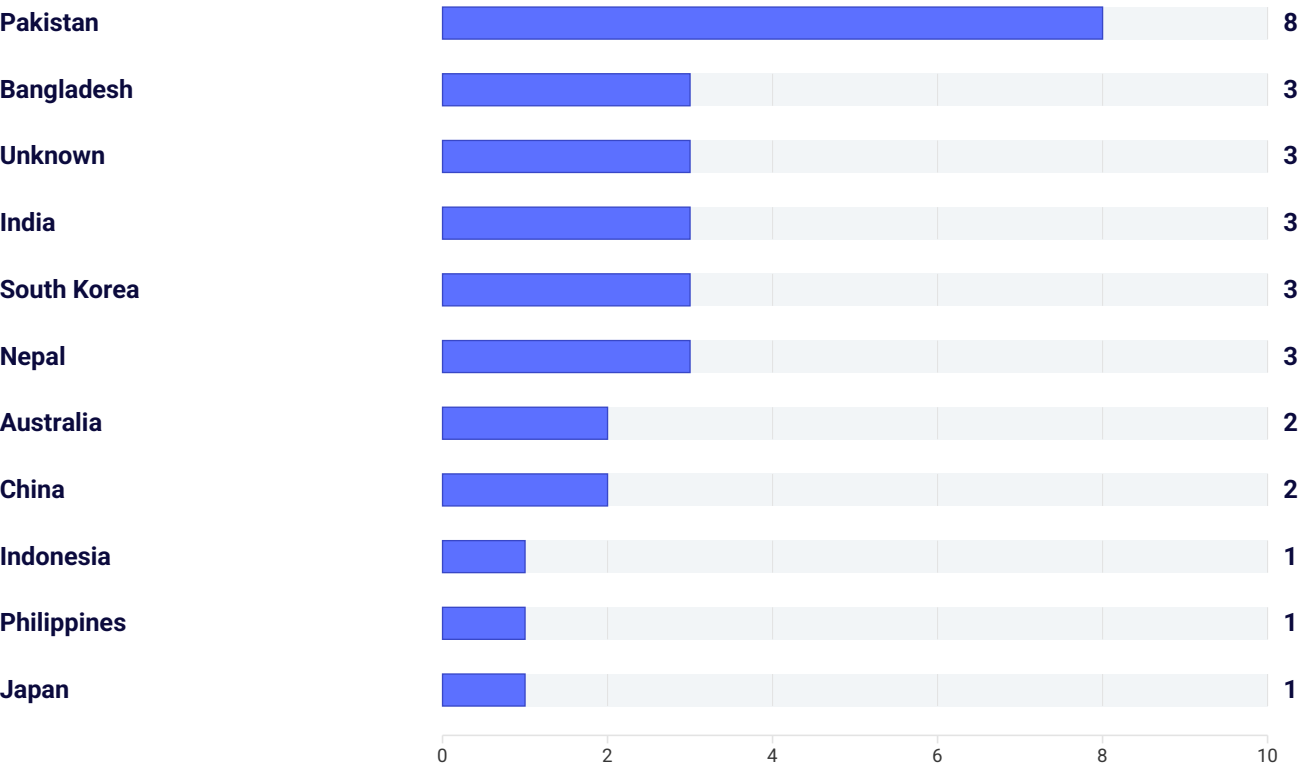
Pakistan - The busiest area this week, driven by protest alongside student activism. Likely form: announced rallies, sectoral walkouts and student-body actions converting into rolling road closures; main areas affected: university campuses, adjoining road networks and exam-board administrative offices.

Bangladesh - The second-busiest area this week, driven by protest alongside other operational incident. Likely form: announced rallies, sectoral walkouts and student-body actions converting into rolling road closures; main areas affected: city-centre commercial districts, transport hubs and government precincts.

Unknown - The third-busiest area this week, driven by strike / labour action alongside protest. Likely form: announced rallies, sectoral walkouts and student-body actions converting into rolling road closures; main areas affected: wholesale markets, transport corridors and sectoral premises (pharmacies, courts, hauliers).

Other APAC countries saw less activity this week and appear in the country chart below.

RECORDS BY COUNTRY



WHAT MATTERS

What matters most this week is that activity is spread across South Asia, East Asia, Southeast Asia and Pacific rather than concentrated in a single capital. That kind of spread is harder to police, harder to predict and routinely turns into rolling, short-notice disruption across several countries in the same week. Pakistan sets the pace but is not the whole picture.

Activity this week leans toward protests rather than civil unrest, which usually means the authorities have held back from visible enforcement. That can change within days if a rally crosses a policy line.

IMPLICATIONS FOR BUSINESS

- Review staff movement plans and journey-management routings across Pakistan and the wider South Asia, East Asia, Southeast Asia and Pacific region against the live protest calendar.
- Set clear work-from-home or delayed-start triggers for offices, plants and customer-facing sites in affected cities.
- Confirm alternative routes for staff, visitors and delivery movements around courts, ministries, campuses and party offices.
- Harden site access controls, perimeter checks and visitor restrictions; pre-position guard reinforcement.
- Pre-approve staff, customer and regulator communications for disruption days so messages move in minutes, not hours.
- Treat any fresh Section 144 / curfew imposition in a city of operation as an immediate WFH trigger and same-day site-closure decision.
- Wire procurement, distribution and customer-service into the security early-warning feed - the trade-group and union walkouts already reported routinely run 24-72 hours ahead of supply-chain friction.

WATCH NEXT

- Bangladesh - Gender-violence protest: road closures and venue-access friction; brief drivers in advance.
- Philippines - Union injunction ruling - sectoral strike risk (Manila): supply-chain friction and sectoral closures 24-72h ahead.
- India - Chemists' strike notice over e-pharmacy rules: supply-chain friction and sectoral closures 24-72h ahead.
- Nepal - Civic protest march: road closures and venue-access friction; brief drivers in advance.
- Pakistan - Faculty / campus protest (Quetta): road closures and venue-access friction; brief drivers in advance.
- Pakistan - Sectoral pay protest by transport / public-sector staff (Islamabad): road closures and venue-access friction; brief drivers in advance.

POLESTAR VIEW

Polestar's view: the picture is broadly mobilised but not yet escalating. Several organising efforts are active; the authorities' response has stayed below visible enforcement so far.

Business disruption risk is moderate-to-elevated: short-notice transport disruption on protest days, closures of public-facing sites driven by Section 144 / curfew orders, and supply-chain friction from trade-group walkouts. The main remaining risk is a trigger - an adverse court ruling, a fuel-price decision, a security-force death - that tips this into sustained unrest.

RELATED INCIDENTS

DATE	ISSUE	TITLE	SEVERITY
18 May 2026	Protest	Bhopal 'dowry death': Twisha Sharma's kin protests in front of MP CM's house; seeks AIIMS post-mortem	HIGH
22 May 2026	Protest	PTI workers stage protests in various cities, defy Section 144 in Islamabad	HIGH
21 May 2026	Protest	Thousands rally in Tokyo against Takaichi government's push to revise pacifist constitution	MODERATE
22 May 2026	Protest	Bangladesh Labour Congress-BNC holds a protest march in front of the National Press Club in the capital on Friday, demanding justice for the brutal murder and rape of all daughters and women, including Ramisa.	LOW
22 May 2026	Protest	Indonesia Gaza Flotilla Protest	LOW
22 May 2026	Protest	Top-10 players plan Roland Garros prize-money protest	LOW

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